obtained secured rights or ownership rights over an area of 6.16 million hectares (i.e., about 4.4 per cent of cultivated area).

Agricultural Land Situation at the End of the 1980s

Bringing more land under agriculture was the stated policy of the government in the first forty years after Independence. In the enthusiasm to distribute as much land as possible, land that was not quite suitable for agriculture was also allotted to farmers and landless labourers in the hope that these lands would expand agriculture in the country.

On the eve of Independence, the state owned vast tracts of land, to which were added large areas of uncultivated wastelands taken over during abolition of intermediaries. These lands were classified as ‘lands which are degraded and cannot fulfil their life-sustaining potential’. The total area of wastelands was estimated to be 63.85 million hectares, 20.17 per cent of total geographical area. Some of these wastelands were also allotted to the landless. Till March 2002, 5.97 million hectares of wastelands have been distributed to the landless poor.

Agricultural land grew by about 20 million hectares to reach an average of about 140 million hectares in the 1970s. It has pretty much stayed at that level for the past four decades. Net irrigated area was smaller at 21 million hectares in 1950; it grew to 48 million hectares at the end of 1990. India’s population increased to about 900 million in 1990. Per-capita availability of agricultural land came down to about 0.15 hectares in 2011.

First-Generation Land Reforms Were a Mixed Bag

India’s track record of land reforms in the period 1947–1990 was mixed.

While impressive land reforms took place in the matter of conferring tenancy/ownership rights to tillers and abolition of intermediaries, the land ceiling laws failed to meet their objectives.